

Miasma

Phlebotomy

Apothecary

Four Humours

Antiseptic

Aseptic

Antibiotic

Vaccination

The medical practice of bloodletting.

Bad air that was believed to cause disease.

The theory that the body is made of blood, phlegm, yellow bile, and black bile.

A medieval pharmacist or chemist.

A completely germ-free environment (e.g. modern operating theatres).

Chemicals used to kill germs on a wound (e.g. Carbolic Acid).

Injecting a weakened or dead version of a disease to create immunity.

A medicine that destroys bacteria (e.g. Penicillin).

**Spontaneous
Generation**

Laissez-faire

**Theory of
Opposites**

**Regimen
Sanitatis**

Theriaca

Buboes

Self-flagellation

Quarantine

A government policy of not interfering in people's lives.

The false belief that rotting matter creates maggots and microbes.

A loose set of healthy living instructions written by physicians to help patients prevent illness through moderate diet, exercise, hygiene, and sleep.

A medical treatment developed by Galen which aimed to restore balance to the body by applying the opposite quality to a dominant humour (e.g., treating a cold with hot peppers).

The painful, pus-filled swellings in the armpits or groin that were the defining physical symptom of bubonic plague.

A popular, complex spice-based herbal remedy containing up to 70 ingredients, widely used as a 'cure-all' in medieval England.

The practice of isolating the sick from the healthy to stop the spread of disease, such as locking infected families inside their homes for 40 days.

The act of whipping oneself in public, practiced by groups of religious zealots (flagellants) to show God they were sorry for their sins in hopes of stopping the plague.

Humanism

Nullius in Verba

Animalcules

Transference

Iatrochemistry

**Dissolution of
the Monasteries**

Circulation

Bills of Mortality

The Latin motto of the Royal Society, meaning 'Take nobody's word for it', which encapsulated the Renaissance shift toward establishing scientific truth through experimentation and empirical evidence rather than traditional authority.

A Renaissance intellectual movement characterized by a love of learning, a renewed interest in classical scholars, and the belief that human beings could use observation and reason to discover the truth for themselves rather than relying solely on religious authority or tradition.

The Renaissance medical theory that an illness or fever could be physically transferred from a patient to another object or animal (e.g., rubbing warts with an onion or sleeping with a sheep).

The term used by Antony van Leeuwenhoek in 1683 to describe the tiny, microscopic living organisms (bacteria) he observed under his improved microscope, which marked the first recorded observation of bacteria but was not yet linked to causing disease.

The action taken by Henry VIII in 1536 to close down Catholic religious institutions, which caused the immediate closure of the vast majority of hospitals in England since they were run by monks and nuns.

Also known as medical chemistry; a popular 17th-century practice inspired by Paracelsus that experimented with chemical preparations, metals, and minerals (like antimony or mercury) as cures rather than relying solely on traditional herbs.

Weekly published sheets in London listing the numbers and causes of deaths in each parish, used during the Great Plague of 1665 to monitor the spread of the epidemic.

The movement of blood around the body through arteries and veins, pumped by the heart, which disproved Galen's ancient theory that blood was constantly produced by the liver.

Searchers

Germ Theory

Bacteriology

Aseptic surgery

Compulsory

Inoculation

Spot Map

DNA

The breakthrough scientific discovery published by Louis Pasteur in 1861 proving that microscopic organisms (microbes) in the air cause decay and disease, which permanently disproved the theory of Spontaneous Generation.

Local officials (usually older women) appointed by authorities during the Great Plague of 1665 to inspect corpses, identify plague deaths, and ensure infected households were quarantined.

A surgical method developed by 1900 where the focus shifted from killing germs already present in a wound (antiseptic) to preventing any germs from entering the operating space entirely using steam-sterilised instruments, sterilized gowns, and rubber gloves.

The scientific study of bacteria, pioneered by Robert Koch who developed rigorous methods to grow, stain, and identify the specific microbes causing individual killer diseases.

The pre-19th century preventative practice of deliberately introducing pus from a mild smallpox scab into a cut on a healthy person's skin, which was expensive, risky, and could trigger a fatal outbreak of the disease.

Required by law or rule; a fundamental shift in government policy seen when the state made smallpox vaccination mandatory in 1852 and forced local councils to provide clean water and sewers in 1875.

Deoxyribonucleic acid; the substance in human cells carrying genetic information that determines hereditary characteristics, discovered as a double helix in 1953 by James Watson and Francis Crick.

A detailed mapping technique created by John Snow during the 1854 Soho outbreak, where he drew marks on a street map to represent cholera deaths and visually trace the source of contamination to the Broad Street water pump.

**Human Genome
Project**

Biopsy

Magic Bullet

Antibiotics

**National Health
Service (NHS)**

Culture Medium

**Therapeutic
Agent**

Bronchoscopy

A diagnostic procedure developed in the twentieth century where a small sample of tissue or flesh is gathered from a patient to be examined by medical scientists in a laboratory, enabling highly accurate diagnosis.

A massive international scientific collaboration launched in 1990 and completed in 2001, which successfully mapped and decoded all three billion DNA pairs in the human body.

Medicines, such as penicillin, that destroy or inhibit the growth of bacteria inside the body to cure infectious diseases, transforming healthcare after their mass production during WWII.

A chemical compound designed to target and kill specific disease-causing microbes inside the body without harming the patient's healthy cells, pioneered by Paul Ehrlich's Salvarsan 606 in 1909.

The nutrient-rich substance (such as agar jelly or liquid broth) used in laboratories to grow and cultivate microbes, which Alexander Fleming used to keep his penicillin samples alive.

A government-funded system launched in 1948 that made comprehensive medical treatment, hospital care, and primary consultations completely free at the point of access for all British citizens.

A high-tech diagnostic procedure where a thin, flexible tube with a camera is passed down a patient's airway into the lungs, allowing doctors to inspect the lung tissue and collect cell samples for biopsy.

A chemical or biological substance developed to actively treat, cure, or heal a specific disease or infection inside a living patient, rather than just acting as a surface antiseptic.

Immunotherapy

Nanny State

**Mobile X-ray
Unit**

Blood Depot

Trench Foot

Trench Fever

Shell Shock

Gas Gangrene

A term used by critics to describe government policies and regulations that actively interfere with or restrict personal lifestyle choices (such as smoking or eating) in the name of protecting public health.

A modern, advanced cancer treatment that works by boosting or stimulating the patient's own immune system, helping it to recognize, target, and destroy cancer cells.

An early form of blood bank developed during the First World War, notably before the Battle of Cambrai in 1917, where donated blood was treated with sodium citrate and glucose to allow storage for emergency transfusions.

A portable radiographic vehicle equipped with a dynamo generator to power an X-ray tube, used close to the frontline on the Western Front to locate shrapnel and bullets inside wounded soldiers.

A highly infectious disease characterized by severe muscle pain and flu-like symptoms, spread among soldiers by body lice that nested in the warm seams of their clothing.

A painful, disabling condition caused by standing for long periods in cold, wet, waterlogged mud, which caused feet to become numb, swollen, and prone to gangrene and amputation if not treated quickly.

A rapid and deadly wound infection caused by anaerobic bacteria found in the heavily manured agricultural soil of Flanders, which thrived in deep, oxygen-depleted wounds caused by shrapnel.

The contemporary term (often recorded by medical staff as NYD.N, or 'Not Yet Diagnosed, Nervous') for the debilitating psychological trauma and mental breakdown caused by constant artillery bombardment.

Shrapnel

Brodie Helmet

**Chain of
Evacuation**

**Casualty
Clearing Station
(CCS)**

**First Aid Nursing
Yeomanry
(FANY)**

Thomas Splint

**Carrel-Dakin
Method**

A steel combat helmet introduced by the British Army in 1915 to protect soldiers' heads from falling shrapnel and shell fragments, which dramatically reduced the rate of fatal head injuries.

The fragments of metal casing scattered by exploding high-explosive artillery shells, which caused the vast majority of battlefield wounds and dragged dirty clothing and infected mud into the body.

Well-equipped medical facilities located several miles behind the front line, close to transport links, where urgent surgery (such as amputations) and critical wound care took place.

The structured series of stages through which wounded soldiers were transported from the frontline trenches to increasingly secure and advanced medical facilities, prioritising speed to prevent infection.

A metal leg splint designed before the war but introduced to the Western Front in 1916, which kept a broken leg rigid during evacuation, reducing the death rate from compound fractures from 80% to under 20%.

A voluntary women's organisation founded in 1907 whose members served on the Western Front as ambulance drivers, mobile kitchen staff, and nurses, providing vital logistical support to the RAMC.

An antiseptic wound treatment developed during WWI where a sterilized chemical solution was continuously pumped through narrow tubes placed deep inside open wounds to kill bacteria and prevent gas gangrene.